MACHINE LEARNING PROJECT · KICKSTARTER

Will my campaign get funded?

Predicting Kickstarter success before launch, from 331,675 past campaigns

[Team names] · Data Science Bootcamp · October 2026

The problem: all or nothing

60%

of finished Kickstarter campaigns **fail**

Miss the goal by $1 → receive $0

Kickstarter only pays out if the funding goal is reached. Every failed campaign costs the creator weeks of work.

Creators decide blind

Goal, category, length and launch date are fixed before launch, with no data on how they affect the odds.

Source: Kickstarter Projects dataset (Kaggle), 331,675 finished campaigns 2009–2018

Our question

Using only what a creator knows **before launch**, how likely is the campaign to succeed?

DATA

331,675 campaigns

Finished between 2009 and 2018, in 15 categories and 22 countries

INPUT

The campaign plan

Goal, category, country, length, launch date and the title

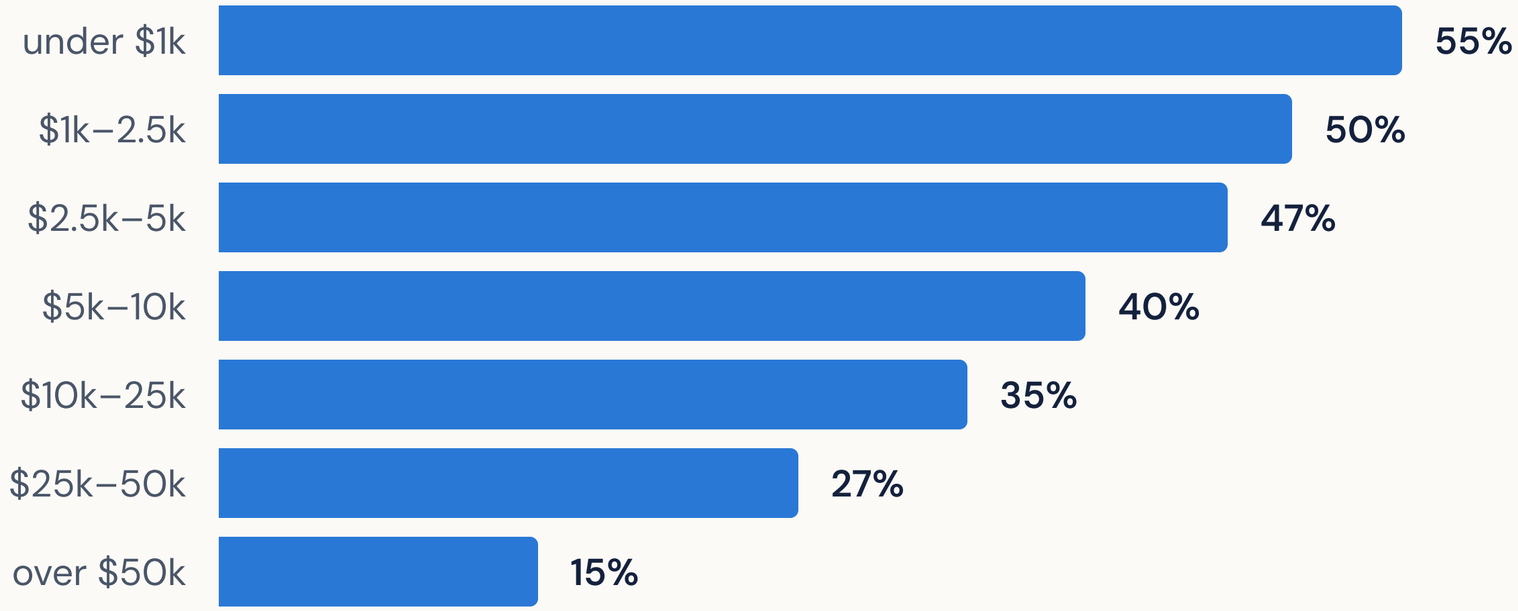
OUTPUT

A success chance

A probability from 0 to 100%, plus a clear yes or no

FINDING 1 · FUNDING GOAL

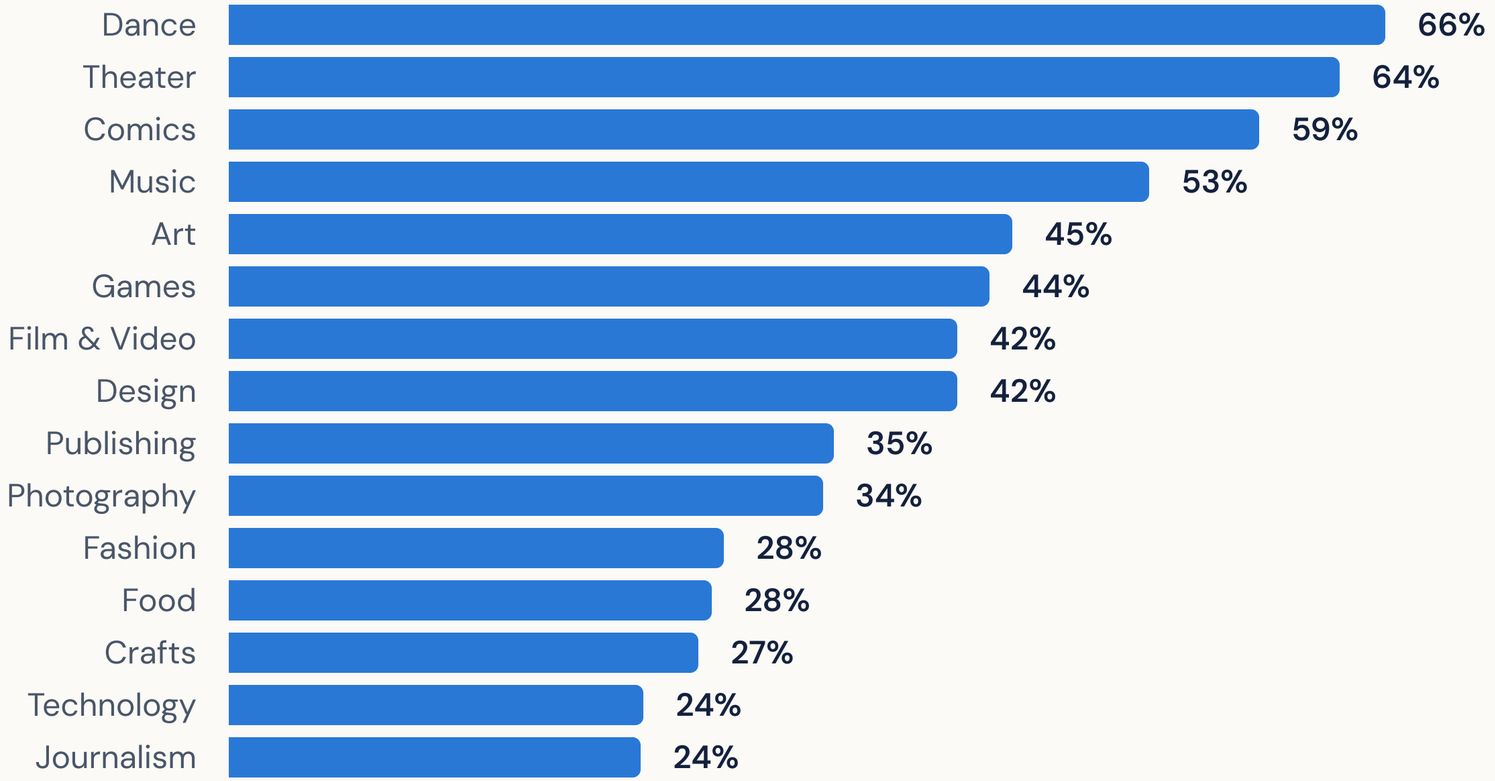
Smaller goals succeed far more often



Share of successful campaigns by funding goal (USD) · training set, 265,340 campaigns · average 40%

FINDING 2 · CATEGORY

Arts beat tech: Dance 66%, Technology 24%

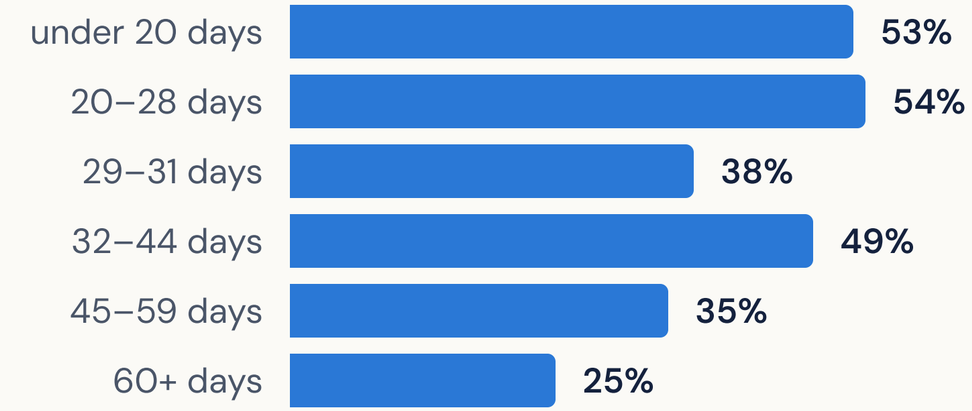


Share of successful campaigns by main category · training set, 265,340 campaigns · average 40%

FINDING 3 · TIMING

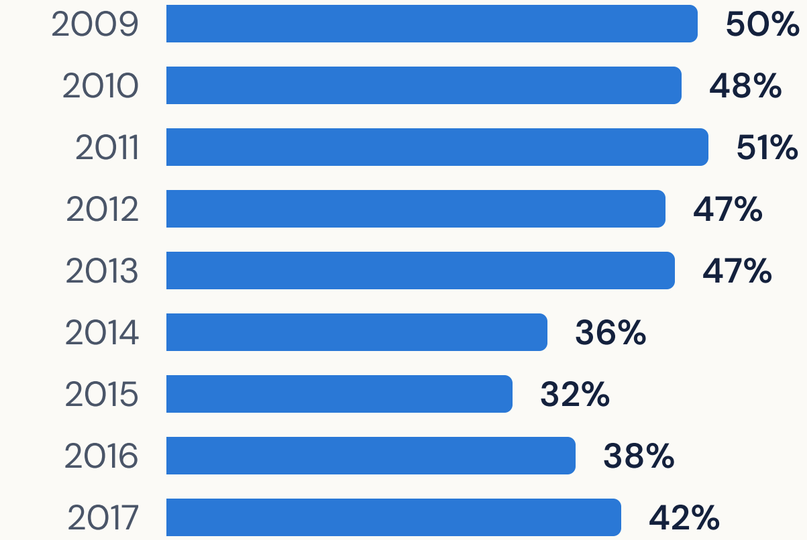
The 30-day default and 60+ days do worst

Campaign length



Half of all campaigns use the 30-day default, and only 38% of those succeed.

Launch year



In 2014 the number of campaigns jumped by 44%, and success rates fell.

Share of successful campaigns · training set, 265,340 campaigns · average 40%

The trap: data from the future

The dataset also holds the **money pledged** and the **number of backers**. Both are only known after the campaign ends.

A model that uses them looks perfect, but is useless on launch day. **We removed them.**

99.997%

of outcomes are explained by one rule: “pledged at least the goal”

How we built it, step by step

1

Clean the data

Keep finished campaigns, remove future data, fix errors

2

Hide a test set

Lock away 20% of campaigns for the final exam

3

Simple rules first

“Small goal = success”: the score to beat

4

Compare 3 models

Linear model, random forest, gradient boosting

5

Tune and test

Tune the best one, then take the exam once

Every model was trained and compared on the other 80% only, using 5-fold cross-validation: train on four parts, check on the fifth, repeat.

RESULT · TESTED ON 66,335 UNSEEN CAMPAIGNS

The model separates risky from promising

Ranking score (ROC-AUC)



Show the model one successful and one failed campaign: it ranks the successful one higher in about **3 out of 4** pairs.

The 10% it rates **most promising**

77%

actually succeeded

The 10% it rates **most risky**

5%

actually succeeded

What it gets right, and where it fails

83%

of successful campaigns found

22,266 of 26,791 successful test campaigns were called “likely to succeed”.

45%

of “success” calls are false hope

18,279 failed campaigns looked promising on paper.

Honest

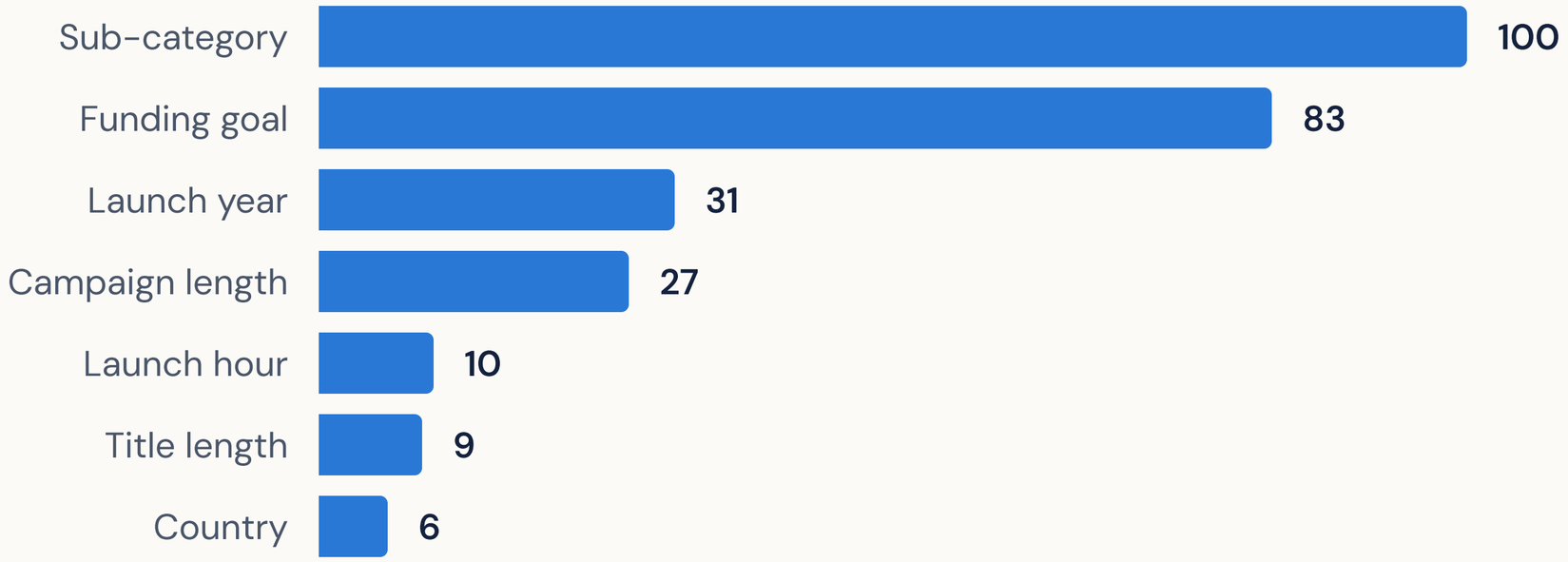
chances you can trust

When the model says 60%, about 60 in 100 such campaigns succeed.

Its biggest misses: tiny board game campaigns that failed, and huge tech and food campaigns that succeeded. The reasons (product quality, audience, marketing) are not in the data.

WHAT THE MODEL LOOKS AT

Category and goal drive the prediction



Importance = how much the model's score drops when that information is scrambled, scaled so the top feature = 100

RECOMMENDATIONS FOR CREATORS

Three things to decide before launch

1

Ask for less

Set the lowest goal that really funds the project. Add extras as stretch goals.

2

Plan the length

Don’t just keep the 30-day default, and avoid 60-day campaigns.

3

Know your category

In Technology, Food or Fashion, build an audience before you launch.

DATA PRODUCT

The Campaign Checker

Example: a US board game. Predicted chance of success:

Goal	21 days	30 days	45 days	60 days
$5,000	**93%**	80%	70%	52%
$10,000	92%	77%	66%	47%
$20,000	88%	69%	63%	37%
$50,000	83%	62%	56%	**27%**

1 · Enter the plan

Category, goal, length, launch date, title

2 · Get the chance

An honest probability, compared with similar campaigns

3 · Try “what if”

See how similar campaigns with a lower goal or another length did

Limits and next steps

What the model can’t do

- Show causes: it finds patterns, not proof
- See the product, video, rewards or the creator’s fan base
- Know the present: the data ends in early 2018
- Avoid false hope: 45% of “success” calls fail

What we would do next

- Add creator history, description text and rewards
- Test on the newest campaigns, trained on older ones
- Refresh with data after 2018
- Build the Checker as a web tool and track its accuracy

Thank you.
Questions?

Ask for less, plan your campaign length, know your category, and check your odds before you launch.

[Team names] · Code and notebook: [GitHub repository link]